

SEXUAL LIBERATION

Changing Sexuality

The Indian female is becoming a multiple choice woman. She is in the job market to stay as a breadwinner, in the universities to teach, in the home if she wants to mother, on the road if she wants to travel, or, in bed enjoying sex as she had never dared to do a generation ago. Going by data, lawyers, counsellors, social scientists, and analysts believe that in the last decade, there has been a sea change in the attitude of urban, middle class women towards themselves, their careers and sexual relationships. Says Dr Jyoti Parikh, gynaecologist, "I see infidelity in women far more during the last decade. The husband fulfils some needs, the boyfriend others. A single man can't do it all." Parikh's view may be a little extreme and applicable to a small segment of highly-westernised Indian women with avant garde, self-indulgent lifestyles. But it is an indicator of a changing sexual climate.

Madhu Jain and Simran Bhargava, October 15, 1989, INDIA TODAY

sex and to say "No" and be "more like men" in terms of sexual experiences and multiple partners. The INDIA TODAY sex surveys capture this attitudinal sea-change. If in 1978, premarital sex was unacceptable to 75 per cent unmarried women in the metros, in the new millennium one-quarter confess to regular sex, one-third read erotic literature and half go on dates. In 2003, over 52 per cent asked for equal pleasure in bed, 42 per cent knew their G-spots well and to 57 per cent orgasms were important. By 2005, 69 per cent wanted as much sex as men, 66 per cent fantasised about different positions in bed and 42 per cent thought nothing of having premarital sex. In a long march from the '70s, over 66 per cent approved of extramarital sex in 2005.

But sexual liberation hasn't arrived in a vacuum. Changes in personal lives have glanced off from changes in public lives. Careers are now blooming. In 1950, there were 14 women pursuing higher studies per 100 males in India. The ratio is now 68:100 (*Report of Consultative Committee of Parliament, 2006*). For

N. THIAGARAJAN



MODEST TALES: The attire of a mannequin being changed in a shop in Karol Bagh in 1962

every five men, there is one woman in an income-generating activity in urban India. Women account for 25-30 per cent of the workforce in the software sector. In pharma, they comprise a fourth of the workforce. In IT-enabled services, the ratio stands at 1:1. The number in banks has gone up by over 40 per cent since 2002. Of the 2,00,000 service sector vacancies filled via job portal *naukri.com* in 2005, 70,000 were women; a quarter of three million resumes on *monster.com* belong to them.

But the battles are not over yet. In many ways, the options presented to women are really, new demands. Professionally, many operate as if they were men. At home, they do most of the housework. Does having it all mean doing it all? Not really. "I think it's a very significant shift," says Urvashi Butalia, publisher of Zubaan Books, which promotes women's writing. "It testifies women's desire to be able to interact on an equal footing both in public and private spheres."

It is nearly 60 years since Simone de Beauvoir famously wrote that one is not born a woman but becomes one. In that time, the nation has taught some of its women that they choose to become women however they want. They can each arrive at their own definition of what a woman is, even if that definition is purely personal. ■